



The Empathy Canvas

Four rings from what they see to what they feel.

45 minutes

Research • UX • Discovery

A3 landscape

v1 • 2026

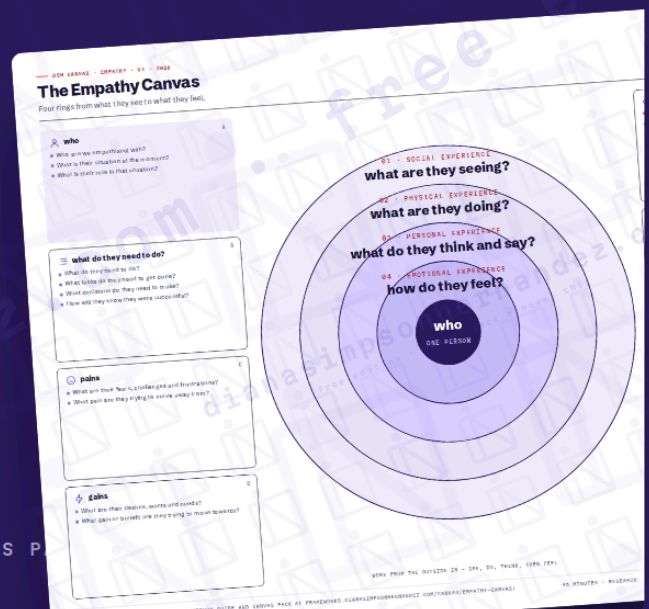
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The Empathy Canvas

Four rings from what they see to what they feel.

Free A3 PDF + quick guide

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— WHAT IT IS

What this canvas does

The empathy canvas is a structured way to stand in one person's situation before you decide what to build for them. The left side establishes the facts — who they are, what they must get done, what they fear and what they want.

— WHEN TO USE IT

- Before any design or product decision that assumes you know the user.
- When a team is arguing about what the customer wants and nobody has evidence.
- As the first forty-five minutes of a discovery workshop, or as a synthesis tool after interviews.

— BOX BY BOX

The short version

01 · WHO

Name one real person or a composite built from at least three interviews. Write their situation and their role in it.

03 · PAINS

Fears, frustrations, and the specific pain they are trying to leave behind.

05 · SOCIAL EXPERIENCE — WHAT ARE THEY SEEING?

What is in their environment, what others around them say and do, and what they read or watch that shapes them.

07 · PERSONAL EXPERIENCE — WHAT DO THEY THINK AND SAY?

Thoughts and real or plausible quotes about the situation.

— WHO IT IS FOR

Product, UX and service teams before they design anything — and founders who have never met their customer. 45 minutes with three to eight people.

02 · WHAT DO THEY NEED TO DO?

List the tasks and decisions in their own words, then write how they would know they had succeeded.

04 · GAINS

Desires, wants, needs, and the benefit they are moving towards.

06 · PHYSICAL EXPERIENCE — WHAT ARE THEY DOING?

Their actual behaviour today. Follow them through a day in your mind and write it down.

08 · EMOTIONAL EXPERIENCE — HOW DO THEY FEEL?

Only now, name the feelings — and tie each to something in the outer rings.

The Canvas Pack (£49) has the full walkthrough for every canvas — what good looks like for each box, a worked example, the agenda and the mistakes — plus clean A3 PDFs and 4K PNGs.
frameworks.dianasimpsonhernandez.com/canvas/